

Moving joints

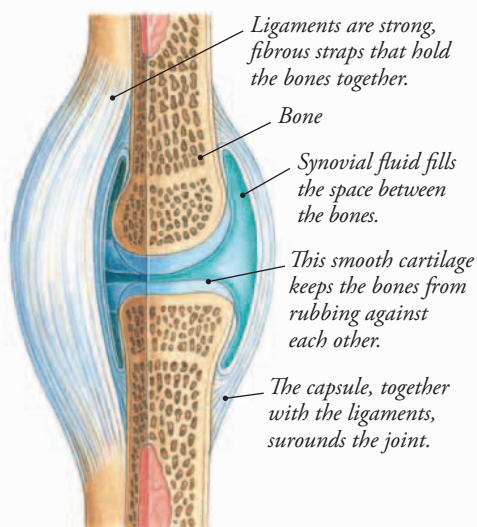
Wherever two or more bones meet in your skeleton, they form a joint. Some of these joints are fixed and rigid. But most are free-moving joints that give your skeleton incredible flexibility, allowing you to run, write, and perform many other movements. Joints also provide stability by holding your bones together.

FLEXIBLE JOINTS

You have six main types of free-moving (synovial) joints in your body. Each joint has its own range of movement depending on how the bones fit together in the joint. The ball-and-socket joint in your hip, for example, allows you to move your leg in most directions, while the hinge joint in your elbow allows for movement in one direction only.

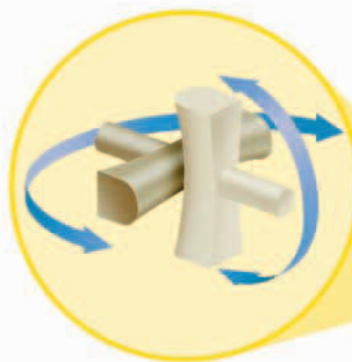
HOW JOINTS WORK

This is an inside view of a synovial joint. It is held together by a tough fibrous capsule. The bone ends are covered by a flexible, rubbery tissue called cartilage and separated by synovial fluid, which helps oil the joint. Together they allow the joint to move smoothly.



► PIVOT JOINT

In this joint, the rounded end of one bone fits within another, like a peg pushed through a hole. Found at the top of your neck, the joint allows you to turn your head from side to side.

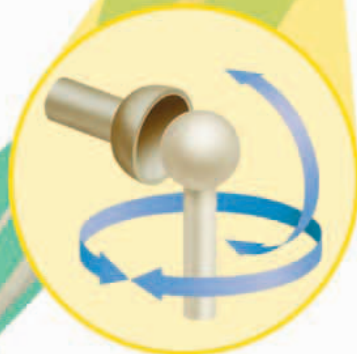


▲ SADDLE JOINT

Your thumb has the only saddle joint in your body. It allows movement in two directions—from side to side and back and forth—making your thumb more flexible than your fingers.

WOW!

There are about 400 joints in the body, and more than 250 of these are free-moving, synovial joints.



▲ BALL-AND-SOCKET JOINT

This flexible joint is formed where the ball-like head of one bone fits into the shallow cup-shaped socket of another. It allows you to swing your arms and legs in most directions.